Ticketing & Refund FAQ

Air ticketing desk - common questions from new joiners. Version 1.0 - for testing OpsMate. Sample content: replace timelines, cut-offs and contacts with your company's actual rules before real use.

1. Basics

Q: What is a PNR?

A: A PNR (Passenger Name Record) is the booking record in the GDS (Amadeus, Sabre or Galileo). It is identified by a 6-character record locator, for example X7K2QM. A PNR must have five mandatory elements before it can be saved: passenger name, itinerary (flight segments), contact phone or email, ticketing arrangement and the received-from field.

Q: What is the difference between a booking and a ticket?

A: A booking (PNR) only reserves the seat. The ticket is the paid travel document that confirms the passenger's right to fly. A booking without a ticket is cancelled automatically by the airline when the ticketing time limit passes.

Q: What is a ticket number and how do I read it?

A: An e-ticket number has 13 digits. The first 3 digits are the airline code (for example 098 is Air India, 176 is Emirates, 125 is British Airways) and the remaining 10 digits are the document number. Always quote the full 13-digit ticket number in case notes and emails.

Q: What is a ticketing time limit (TTL)?

A: The ticketing time limit is the deadline set by the airline or fare rules by which the booking must be ticketed. If the ticket is not issued by the TTL the airline cancels the booking. Always check the TTL in the PNR and issue or get approval before it expires.

Q: What is a fare basis code and where do I find the fare rules?

A: The fare basis code (for example YLOWUS or QRTIN) identifies the exact fare and its conditions. Display the fare rules in the GDS from the priced fare. The most important rule categories are Category 16 (penalties), Category 31 (voluntary changes) and Category 33 (voluntary refunds).

2. Booking and ticket issuance

Q: What must I check before issuing a ticket?

A: Before issuing, check: 1. passenger name matches the passport exactly; 2. dates, flights and routing match the request; 3. fare and fare rules (refundable or not, change fee); 4. travel policy compliance and approval if required; 5. correct form of payment; 6. frequent flyer number and special service requests; 7. traveller contact details in the PNR.

Q: How do I issue a ticket?

A: Steps to issue a ticket: 1. Price the PNR with the correct fare and passenger type. 2. Store the fare (TST in Amadeus, PQ in Sabre). 3. Verify the fare, taxes and form of payment. 4. Issue the ticket with the ticketing entry. 5. Confirm the 13-digit ticket number appears in the PNR. 6. Email the itinerary and e-ticket receipt to the traveller and add case notes.

Q: When do I need approval before ticketing?

A: Approval from the traveller's manager or travel manager is required when the booking is outside travel policy: business class on flights under 6 hours, fares above the lowest logical fare, bookings made less than 7 days before travel, or non-preferred airlines. Save the approval email in the case before issuing.

Q: What is a duplicate booking and why is it a problem?

A: A duplicate booking is the same passenger booked on the same or overlapping flights in more than one PNR. Airlines treat duplicates as a violation and can charge the agency an ADM. Always search for existing PNRs before creating a new booking and cancel any duplicate segments immediately.

3. Void

Q: What is a void?

A: A void cancels a ticket completely as if it was never issued. No penalty applies and the full amount is reversed to the form of payment. A void is only possible within the void window and only if no coupon has been used.

Q: What is the void deadline (until when can I void)?

A: The void window is the same calendar day as ticket issuance, before the desk void cut-off of 23:00 local desk time (sample policy). After the cut-off the ticket can no longer be voided and must be refunded or exchanged under the fare rules.

Q: When can a ticket not be voided?

A: A ticket cannot be voided after the void cut-off, if any flight coupon has been used or checked in, if the ticket was created by an exchange (reissue) on some carriers, or if the airline has already processed it. In these cases process a refund or exchange instead.

4. Refunds

Q: How do I process a refund?

A: Refund steps: 1. Retrieve the PNR and check the ticket status is OPEN (unused) or partially used. 2. Check Category 33 / Category 16 fare rules for the refund conditions and cancellation fee. 3. Run the automated refund quote in the GDS and verify the refundable fare and taxes. 4. Get written confirmation from the traveller or travel manager. 5. Process the refund and record the refund number in the case notes. 6. Send the refund confirmation email within 2 hours.

Q: How long does a refund take to reach the traveller?

A: Refund time / timeline: once processed, card refunds normally reach the traveller in 7 to 10 business days, depending on the airline and the card issuer. Refunds that need airline approval (manual refunds, waivers) can take 4 to 8 weeks. Share the refund number with the traveller so they can follow up with their bank.

Q: Is anything refundable on a non-refundable ticket?

A: On a non-refundable ticket the fare itself is not refunded, but most government taxes and airport fees are usually refundable if the ticket is unused. Carrier-imposed surcharges (YQ/YR) are often not refundable. Always run the refund quote to see the exact refundable taxes.

Q: What is a partial refund?

A: A partial refund applies when part of the journey has been flown, for example the outbound is used and the return is not. The refund is the value of the unused portion calculated under the fare rules, minus any penalty. Use the GDS refund function for partially used tickets; never calculate it manually without Team Lead approval.

Q: What is the US 24-hour cancellation rule?

A: For flights to, from or within the United States, if the booking was made at least 7 days before departure, the traveller can cancel within 24 hours of booking and receive a full refund without penalty (or the airline offers a 24-hour hold instead). Check the airline's own 24-hour policy and act within the 24 hours.

Q: The traveller cancels a non-refundable ticket. What happens to the money?

A: Do not refund the fare. Cancel the flights in the PNR before departure so the ticket stays OPEN, and keep the ticket value as a credit for future travel, minus the change fee. Most tickets can be used for a new booking within 1 year from the original issue date. Record the unused ticket in the unused ticket tracker.

Q: A refund was rejected or the amount is disputed. What do I do?

A: Do not reprocess. Escalate to your Team Lead within 4 business hours with the ticket number, refund quote and fare rules screenshot. Fare-related disputes go to the Fares desk; airline rejections are raised with the airline's agency support desk.

5. Changes and exchanges

Q: How do I change the travel date on an issued ticket?

A: Steps to change the date: 1. Check Category 31 fare rules for change fee and conditions. 2. Book the new flight in the PNR. 3. Reprice as an exchange to get the fare difference, tax difference and change fee. 4. Get the traveller's approval for the additional collection. 5. Reissue the ticket and confirm the new ticket number. 6. Send the updated itinerary.

Q: What is a reissue (exchange)?

A: A reissue, also called an exchange, replaces an issued ticket with a new ticket after a change. The old ticket is exchanged against the new one, and the traveller pays the fare difference, tax difference and change fee if any. The new ticket has a new ticket number.

Q: What is a revalidation?

A: A revalidation updates the existing ticket for a flight or date change without issuing a new ticket. It is only allowed when the airline, booking class, fare and routing stay the same and the fare rules permit it. If any of these change, a reissue is needed.

Q: Can a passenger change the name on a ticket?

A: Minor name corrections (spelling mistakes of up to 3 characters, or adding a missing middle name) are allowed on most airlines, sometimes with a fee. A full name change to a different person is not allowed: the ticket must be refunded or cancelled and a new ticket issued for the new traveller.

6. Airline schedule changes and disruptions

Q: What do I do when the airline changes the flight schedule?

A: For an airline schedule change (involuntary change): 1. Review the new timings and check the connection still works. 2. Accept the change in the PNR or rebook on the best alternative under the airline waiver. 3. Inform the traveller within 4 hours. 4. If the change is significant (usually more than 2 hours or a missed connection), the traveller may choose a full involuntary refund without penalty.

Q: The airline cancelled the flight. What are the options?

A: When the airline cancels the flight the traveller can be rebooked on the next available flight at no cost, or receive an involuntary refund of the unused portion. For flights from the EU or on EU airlines, the traveller may also claim EU261 compensation directly from the airline.

7. Special requests

Q: How do I add a meal or wheelchair request?

A: Add a Special Service Request (SSR) to the PNR, for example VGML for vegetarian meal or WCHR for wheelchair. Check the SSR status changes to confirmed (HK or KK). Meal requests should be added at least 24 hours before departure and wheelchair requests at least 48 hours before.

Q: How do I add a frequent flyer number?

A: Add the frequent flyer number as an FQTV element in the PNR before ticketing. The airline or alliance must match the operating or marketing carrier. Tell the traveller that miles not credited can be claimed from the airline later with the ticket number.

Q: Can I book seats and extra baggage for the traveller?

A: Free seats can be assigned in the GDS seat map. Paid seats and extra baggage are ancillaries: book them through the GDS ancillary function or the airline website and charge them only with approval under the travel policy. Always send the traveller the EMD (receipt) number.

8. Quality and escalation

Q: What is an ADM and how do I avoid it?

A: An ADM (Agency Debit Memo) is a charge an airline sends to the agency for a booking or ticketing violation. Common causes are duplicate bookings, fictitious names, wrong fares or tax codes, and churning (repeatedly cancelling and rebooking). Avoid ADMs by following the fare rules, cancelling unused segments on time and never holding fake bookings.

Q: What is the escalation matrix?

A: Level 1: Senior Agent, within 2 hours. Level 2: Team Lead, within 4 hours. Level 3: Process Manager, same business day. VIP travellers and same-day departures escalate directly to Level 2. For urgent airline issues on same-day departures, call the airline's agency desk immediately and update the case.

Q: What do I do if I am stuck or unsure?

A: Do not guess and do not issue, void or refund if you are unsure. First ask OpsMate and check the SOP source, then ask your Senior Agent. Write clear case notes of what was checked and what is pending, so the next person can continue without starting again.